THE RATIFICATION OF THE 2012 CAPE TOWN AGREEMENT

Honourable Deputy Speaker

Honourable members

My sincere appreciation for lending me the opportunity to add my contribution to the motion before us on the ratification of the 2012 Cape Town Agreement on the implementation of the provisions of Protocol relating the Torremolinos International Convention for the safety of fishing vessels, 1977.

The Ministry is appreciative of the effort by the Ministry of Works and Transport of ratifying the 2012 Cape Town Agreement. Primarily, this agreement of safety on fishing vessels had direct implication to the fishing sector which our ministry is entrusted to administer.

The state and safety of a fishing vessel is a primary prerequisite for licensing of a fishing vessel to venture into fishing activities. Before our Ministry issues a fishing license to a fishing vessel, the applicant is request to present a Fishing Vessel Safety Certificate issued by the Ministry of Works and Transport certifying the fitness of such a vessel to venture into sea operations, without compromising the safety of the crew onboard or other vessels within its vicinity. I am confident that the Ministry of Works and Transport diligently conducts inspections and surveys on all vessels, including fishing vessels, to confirm that lifesaving appliance and related equipment, radio installations, and structure, machinery and equipment are well installed and functional. These inspections and surveys aspects are well accounted for under the Merchant Shipping Act, 1951 (Act 57 of 1951) which guides the Ministry of Works and Transports on its mandates.

It is therefore imperative that ratification of the 2012 Cape Town Agreement that complement the Merchant Shipping Act on the afore-mentioned aspects is whole heartly welcomed. It surfaces to say that the safety of fishing vessels is paramount with sequential implications, if not well managed. As a member to International Maritime Organization (IMO) and International Labour Organization Conventions (ILO), the safety of sea-going personal is of importance to us, not only that they are Namibians but also because the fishing sector significantly contributes to our economic wellbeing. Further, the state/ condition of a fishing vessel is an indicator of a vessel engaging is suspicious activities, including illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing activities.

Illegal, unreported, and unregulated (IUU) fishing is one of the greatest global threats to aquatic ecosystems due to its ability to undermine national and regional efforts to manage fisheries sustainably and conserve biodiversity. IUU fishing takes advantage of compromised

administrations and exploits weak management systems, particularly where lack of capacity and resources for effective monitoring, control, and surveillance (MCS) are limited.

Hon Deputy Speaker, Namibia is recognised among the nations with, at a minimum, a moderate MCS program, much so on the African continent. Such a program is very costly and that is why many countries globally are challenged in protecting and responsibly managing their aquatic resources, which proliferate IUU fishing.

IUU fishing occurs in all types and dimensions of fisheries; it occurs both on the high seas and in areas within national jurisdiction, it concerns all aspects and stages of the capture and utilisation of fish, and can be associated with organized crime. Fisheries resources available to local fishery are removed by IUU fishing, which can lead to the collapse of national fisheries; with valuable contribution to the country' economy and its people wellbeing. IUU fishing derived fish products outcompete legitimate products in overseas trade markets and suppress national supply. Therefore, IUU fishing threatens livelihoods, exacerbates poverty, augments fishery insecurities and should not be taken lightly.

Hon Deputy Speaker, it is with that understanding that the Ministry of Fisheries and Marine Resources considers the ratification of the 2012 Cape Town Agreement an addition to our arsenals in the fight against IUU fishing. This ratification complements many other instruments that we have ratified in our quest against IUU fishing.

The Ministry thus regards this ratification appropriate in enhancing the implementation of our mandate in conserving and protecting our aquatic living resources for a sustainable utilisation of the current generation and generations to come after us.

I thus, wholeheartedly support the ratification.

I THANK YOU